Critical Thinking Rubric for Essay Rating

This rubric is based on an early version of the Critical Thinking Progression for High School Students developed by the Skills for the Future (SFF) initiative, a partnership between ETS and The Carnegie Foundation for the Advancement of Teaching. The current version of the Skills Progression can be seen here: https://www.ets.org/pdfs/sff/skills-progressions.pdf. The progression has four levels intended for understanding skill acquisition during secondary school. The project continues to iterate on ways to portray the ways in which skill development is not linear and is currently working to validate these progressions with educators and students.

Critical Thinking					
Definition: *Critical thinking involves the skill and disposition to actively seek and evaluate information and construct evidence-based arguments to reach well-founded conclusions or informed decisions, including recognizing and applying sound logical reasoning. It plays an important role in learning activities, such as evaluating multiple sources, identifying assumptions, and reasoning flaws, and making sound arguments. Developing strong critical thinking skills enables students to tackle complex challenges more effectively and achieve greater learning outcomes.* Argument Structure Explainer					
Subskill	**Not Applicable** *(Certain critical thinking elements are absent from the student contribution, which inhibits a proficiency rating.)*	**Below Emerging** *(Not yet identifying or understanding key aspects of critical thinking.)*	**Emerging** *(Noticing and Exploring: Beginning to identify and understand key aspects of critical thinking.)*	**Expanding** *(Applying and Refining: Developing skills to improve seeking and analyzing information, generating arguments, and recognizing / applying sound logical reasoning.)*	**Exemplifying** *(Mastering and Advancing: Demonstrating proficiency and a self-directed disposition toward thinking critically consistently and efficiently.)*
Subskill 2: Information Analysis					
2.1: Synthesizing Multiple Sources (Effectively synthesizes multiple pieces of information)	Does not cite any sources	Cites only one source	Summarizes information from multiple sources (with citations) but does not integrate the information	Integrates information from multiple sources (with citations) to explicitly identify relationships and patterns (e.g., compare/contrast)	Integrates information from multiple sources (with citations) to form insights and connections beyond

					information cited from each source
2.2: Evaluating Evidence Strength (Evaluates the strength and relevance of evidence used to form a conclusion) Evidence is anything used to support a claim, which can include both facts and opinions / anecdotes.	Does not present any evidence	Presents evidence but does not link evidence to a specific conclusion and does not evaluate the relevance or strength of the evidence for the argument generated (i.e., evidence is only listed) *Note* - If there is no specific conclusion provided, this is the highest code when evidence has been provided.	Presents evidence and links evidence to a specific conclusion, but does not evaluate the relevance or strength of the evidence for the argument generated	Presents evidence and accurately articulates distinctions between weaker and stronger evidence used to form a specific conclusion	Presents evidence, articulates distinctions between weaker and stronger evidence to form a specific conclusion, and provides an explanation for their evaluation (e.g., why a piece of evidence is stronger or weaker).
Subskill 3: Argument Generation					
3.1: Using Counterarguments (Effectively addresses counterarguments) Counterarguments may also include qualifiers (see Argumentation slide below)	No opposing view(s), counterargument(s), or qualifier(s) acknowledged or no specific conclusion is drawn (e.g., the position of the argument is unclear) and thus it is not possible to determine opposing view, counterargument, or qualifier status	Acknowledges general or vague opposing view(s),counterargument(s), or qualifier(s) (e.g., 'others may disagree')	Acknowledges specific opposing viewpoint(s), counterargument(s) or qualifier(s)	Acknowledges opposing viewpoint(s),counterargument(s), or qualifier(s), and develops response(s) to them	Acknowledges opposing viewpoint(s),counterargument(s), or qualifier(s), evaluates them (refuting them when appropriate or considering them when they are reasonable), and integrates multiple perspectives into a coherent and reasonable argument

3.2: Using Facts and Opinions (Relies on data and/or facts over opinions) Claims are not considered as facts or opinions.	Only uses opinions to support claim(s) and/or argument (no data and/or facts presented)	Uses more opinions than facts to support claim(s) and/or argument	Uses facts and opinions about equally to support claim(s) and/or argument	Uses more facts than opinions to support claim(s) and/or argument	Uses more facts than opinions to support claim(s) and/or argument, including discussion of the source, quality, and/or nature of facts and opinions
Subskill 4: Logical Reasoning for Critical Thinking					
4.1: Drawing Conclusions (Draws specific conclusions) See Argumentation slide below	—	No specific conclusion is drawn (e.g., the position of the argument is unclear)	Draws a specific conclusion to analyze simple and straight-forward relationships / argumentations	Draws a specific conclusion using valid assumptions (e.g., factually correct claims) to analyze complex relationships / argumentations	Draws a specific conclusion using valid assumptions to analyze complex relationships / argumentations, and articulates the relationships / argumentations accurately (e.g., assumptions, evidence, claims)
4.2: Using Logical Fallacies (Recognizes and avoids logical fallacies) “Fallacies are common errors in reasoning that will undermine the logic of your argument.” (see examples in Logical Fallacy Explainer).	Uses only logical fallacies (one type or more) when generating arguments	Uses more logical fallacies than evidence when generating arguments	Uses logical fallacies and evidence about equally when generating arguments	Uses more evidence than logical fallacies when generating arguments	Uses more evidence than logical fallacies when generating arguments, avoids most or all logical fallacies and articulates the nature of these fallacies (e.g., causation fallacy, false equivalency, etc.)

Evidence is anything used to support a claim, which can include both facts and opinions / anecdotes (see Subskill 2.2).					

Argumentation Slide

Argumentation

https://owl.purdue.edu/owl/general_writing/academic_writing/historical_perspectives_on_argumentation/toulmin_argument.html

